

RAJNI
BECTOR

67, FOOD SPECIALIST

FOUNDER AND CHAIRPERSON, CREMICA

INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1983 Rs 20,000

CURRENT TURNOVER

Rs 450 crore



REUBEN SINGH

**biggest
SUCCESS**

Their joint venture with food MNCs like Kerry Ingredients and the Quaker Oats Company

**success
MANTRA**

Expansion and cost-effectiveness are key elements for growth

**turning
POINT**

Their association with McDonald's as a major supplier of buns and sauces in 1996

BAKING IT IN

In Ludhiana's entrepreneurial incubator, Rajni Bector's success story stands out for its distinct and delectable flavour. What started out as a homemaker's hobby is now a flourishing Rs 450-crore food enterprise. The 67-year-old's brand 'Mrs Bector's Cremica' rolls out 10,000 tonnes of biscuits, 1,500 tonnes of sauces and 35 lakh bread loaves a month. The company, in which she is assisted by husband Dharamvir, 77, and sons, Ajay, 49, Akshay, 47, and Anoop, 45, is growing at 30 per cent a year.

It all started in 1983, when Rajni and her husband invested Rs 20,000 in some basic ice-cream making equipment, converting the backyard of their home in Ludhiana's Sarabha Nagar into a baking facility. It was her way to fight boredom with her sons at a boarding school in Patiala. With the little catering company taking off at weddings and parties, she set up her first bread-making unit outside Ludhiana in 1988 with a loan of Rs 48 lakh. By 1991, her venture turned into fam-

ily business, having diversified into biscuit-manufacturing with a daily capacity of 15 tonnes.

The breakthrough, however, came in 1996 when they entered into a partnership with McDonald's. "This helped us grow fast as it brought lot of expertise and management systems to our operations," says Ajay. Today, McDonald's is their single major customer, accounting for nearly 10 per cent of their turnover which is expected to touch Rs 600 crore by 2010. But the group's major growth has been in the biscuit business, accounting for 65 per cent of its turnover. From almost nothing in 2003, they now export products worth Rs 100 crore to 50 countries. The company's next plan is to venture into ready-to-eat packed ethnic dishes. While her company is expected to be a Rs 1,000-crore conglomerate by 2011, Rajni makes it a point to advise her sons. "Expansion is the only way to survive," she says.

by Ramesh Vinayak